

Gary and I strolled outside with our coffee, and he started shedding some light on his background. “So there I was, in the Army and on my way to combat as a medic ...” I interrupted, “Wait, you are a Vietnam vet? I was a captain in the United States Marine Corps and an Iraq vet!” We both looked at each other, amused at this unanticipated congruity. I knew that a military background often drives certain character traits that are useful in the investing world. Next, Gary continued describing his unique background, “Yeah, I’ve done some cool things. I lived in India for a few years, went on tour as a comedy magician for a while, was an award-winning artist, and I have an MBA from the Harvard Business School.” Perplexed, I had to stop him, “Say again?”

After about an hour went by and my head stopped spinning from listening to the various exploits Gary had engaged in over the years, I had to ask him the question: “Gary, sounds like you’re a guy that never wanted to get a real job—why didn’t you become an academic? You’d be perfect!” And of course, as I should have anticipated, he replied, “Wes, funny you ask. I almost followed your same path when I was your age. I applied to the Chicago Finance PhD program and was accepted. I really wanted to be an academic researcher.” It all began to make sense. I questioned, “Well, what happened?” Gary, always ready with the right answer, replied, “Well, I almost pursued that opportunity, but I was making a ton of money trading options. Plus, I didn’t believe in the efficient market hypothesis, and I worried that if I entered the program I would have to give up making money because they were saying the markets couldn’t be beat!” I pondered Gary’s response and thought that had I been faced with the same opportunity, I would probably have done the same thing.

So what is the moral of the story here, and why have I spent so much time describing my relationship and experience with Gary? My hope is that you can identify, as I did, that Gary is a unique person with unique talents. Gary has a way of compiling massive amounts of research from diverse areas and synthesizing it in such a way that even a struggling momentum half-wit like me can actually comprehend what is going on. And make no mistake. What Gary has done is extremely challenging. It requires broad-ranging knowledge and an ability to connect the dots across many domains. I know, because I have tried. My own research on value investing and behavioral finance led to my coauthored book on value investing, *Quantitative Value*. My takeaways were similar to Gary’s. My book serves